

Critical reflection on Critical Vernacular as of
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The idea of the vernacular is firstly that which I personally find offensive due to the nature of its conception - that which is considered inferior, or other to, the main idea of - Architecture. The idea of the Other in the first place is best described as Subaltern, as explained by Gayatri Spivak (postcolonial theorist) as an articulation of a group of oppressed or discriminated against individuals that have responded in past or present to a colonial power (not necessarily literally colonial, but a dominating and "superior" entity).

The fundamentals of postcolonialism is vital to understanding Critical Vernacular or Critical Regionalism as an applicable theory.

In Concepts of Vernacular Architecture, Robert Brown and Daniel Maudlin particularly speak towards postcolonial concepts of temporality and existence of the vernacular - the attitude towards place and form-making completely differs from the conservative conception of rigid built form.

So-called vernacular architecture refers broadly to the historical, or "primitive" responses of indigenous peoples to the region - I prefer to think of this as an indigenous knowledge system of problem-solving from first principles, developing technologies and design solutions from scratch without precedents, using raw materials, processes and peoples. There are most definitely remnants of such interventions in rural areas of some countries, or places left untouched by (not civilisation) capitalism and globalisation.

Critical thinking itself is the ability to behave as a true contrarian - as specified in today's lecture, the attitude of being critical of itself - not behaving contrarily for the sake of doing so. Constantly choosing the contrary is conforming of a different sort. An illustration of this example would be rooted in the assumption that creating new architectures to perfectly imitate the impression of historical vernacular aesthetics, dwellings, patterns or spatial arrangements. Mere imitations are reductive and patronising, and uncritical in their applications - rendering them useless and offensive. An Ndebele geometric design painted on a wall does not automatically make a building an Ndebele-friendly space, to be arb.

In this kind of sense, critical vernacular is the constant merging and contextualising of indigenous technologies in a way that is appropriate to the site's current function and space in history.

Kenneth Frampton best describes critical regionalism using a series of elements or guiding features that enables one to differentiate main differences between "normative" architecture vs. the Subaltern.

One of these are the tactile vs. scenographic - the scenographic approach is that which is currently favoured by global architects, surrendering to aesthetics, the idea that a building is to

be observed and admired from afar, serving a purely functional role, and performing efficiently while looking pretty. This is a very non-disruptive application of form vs. function.

Instead, Frampton directs attention to the way tactility is manifested in ethnic/indigenous cultures - the act of building as a process, self-building that leaves clear tectonic and material language as an expression of form. This approach towards built form is designed to cater to the human experience by engaging all senses and the idea of building as an act that belongs to the human body - that which is seen, heard, smelled, touched, but most importantly, tasted.

By learning from just one of these principles, the critical approach would be to use both scenographic and tactile ideas in a building that requires both in a specific proportion, to be decided by the architect (responsibly) for that specific context.

This singular principle illustrates how critical vernacular uses old and new to form an ever-evolving approach to what is considered Architecture.